

where at all. It started with e-mail: if you knew a person's e-mail address, you could send him or her a letter in an instant regardless of geography. Snail mail suddenly seemed this quaint little rustic tool that only tech illiterate people and the elderly used to communicate.

Then, in accordance with the laws of human nature, our tendency to want to socialise asked for more. Thus the platform was set: we wanted instantaneous communication, and not just with the people we knew—we wanted to make new friends from various countries.

It was this need that prompted Jarkko Oikarinen, an employee of the Department of Information Processing Science in the University of Oulu, Finland, to sit down and write out the code for the first ever IRC client and server in 1988. IRC stands for Internet Relay Chat, and basically, it's a tool that let you chat over the Net. Prior to this, the only way you could communicate with others was through the BBS (Bulletin Board System) that was around before "the Internet" came in.

IRC was amazing at the time, and got people really excited. You could actually connect to a server, see hundreds of people online and then chat with them (gasp!). As early as July 1990, there were as many as 40 servers running worldwide, each with an average of 12 users. This meant that as much as a hundred users could be online at once and chat *in real-time*.

There's plenty more to the history of IRC, but we won't get into it here. Suffice it to say that popularity shot up, especially during the first Gulf War of 1991, when IRC was found to be the best way to send information across the world in the shortest span of time. It was in 1991 that the IRC network first saw over 300 people online at the same time.

Since IRC had the concept of channels (basically chat rooms), it wasn't long before people started creating channels based on